VOL 7: THE THIEF.

THE FOULANE FAMILY



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Vol 7. The Walad gang

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The Foulane Family

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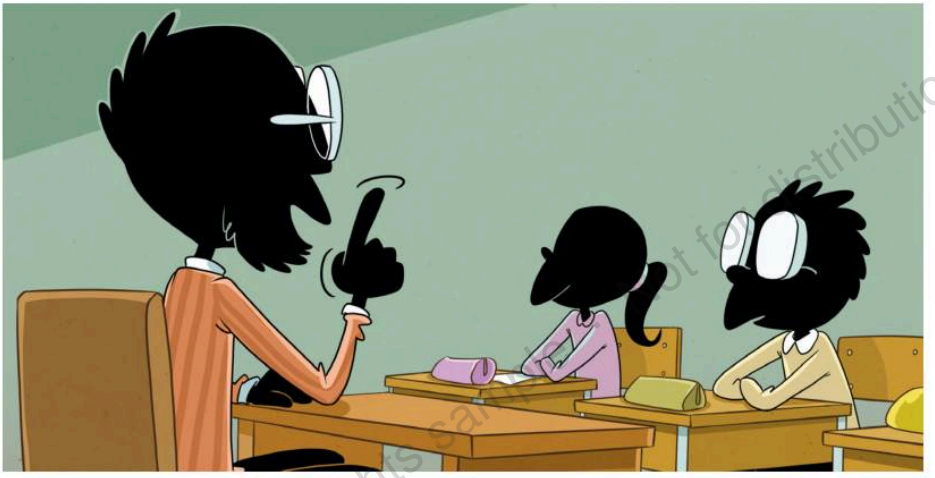
1. On the board!

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As much as I love talking to you and telling you all kinds of stories, I always had one fear at school: going to the blackboard. I am terrified of being alone, standing up and facing the whole class.

So just imagine how I felt the day the teacher announced this:



“Children, listen up. In order to prepare you for your future adult life, I am organising a public speaking contest. Each week, one of you will come up to the front and present to us all about an animal of your choice for five minutes. You will also have to prepare a short presentation to support your pitch.”

“Sir, what is a pchitt?” Rachid asked.

“It’s like those trigger bottles you use when cleaning windows,” explained Jeremy. “They make a ‘pchitt’ noise when you use them.”

“That’s called a spray, you nincompoop,” interrupted Lily, in her thick American accent. “I always have one with me so I can put glitter in my hair.”

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"Hmm... not quite, children," the teacher replied. "A pitch is a term for a short presentation. In the workplace, they might called it an 'elevator pitch'."



"We need to give our pitch in an elevator?" asked Rachid. "But the school only has stairs, there aren't any lifts!"

"Huh?" replied Lily.

"No! Just no!" the teacher continued. "Listen, forget the word 'pitch' would you? You just need to remember that you must prepare your presentation as soon as possible. The contest starts next week insha'Allah."

At the end of the class, all the children left to see the list posted on the wall. All of the names of the students were written on the paper, in alphabetical order.



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As my name starts with a W, I was going to be the last to present... phew! Anass, on the other hand, was first.

"Woah. You're going first!" I said to Anass. "Which animal are you going to talk about?"

"You'll see... Wauaarhh!!" He replied with a roar.

During break time, while Jeremy and Anass were busy scribbling out their presentations on loose papers, I noticed that Rachid was looking uncomfortable.

"What's the matter? You don't look good."



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"It's this public speaking competition... I'm afraid I'll be laughed at." Rachid said.

"But why?" I asked.

"You've seen what happens. When I speak, I often get my fires crossed."

"Wires"

"Huh?"

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"The saying is 'wires crossed'... not fires. Honestly, don't worry. Everything will be fine insha'Allah."

"That's easy for you to say! You speak well!" Rachid replied.

"That's what you think... But actually, I'm terrified of going up to the front by the blackboard." I exclaimed.

"Well, why?"

"I don't know... I think I'm shy."



"Okay, so we're both in the same boat..." Rachid offered.

"The same boat? Who said anything about going to sea!" I replied.

"Ahh... no... that's not what I meant. You see what I mean about me getting confused about things!"

Rachid was right. The pair of us were the same. This whole public speaking contest wasn't looking very good at all. Especially since the other participants seemed rather motivated.

"I'm going to make the best presentation in the class!!" Anass exclaimed.

"And me, from the whole school!!" outbid Jeremy.

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A week later, it was time for the first presentation. And as expected, it was Anass who was kicking off the series.

He went to the front of the class with a big cardboard tube from which he puled out some large sheets of paper. He attached them to the blackboard with magnets.



"Today I'd like to tell you about the Bengaaaaaaale tiger!" proclaimed Anass while moving into a karate position.

"Anass, do you agree that this in an animal presentation and NOT a karate demonstration?" asked the teacher, sternly.



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“Rkhhryesss, sir!” roared Anass, deep in his role. One at a time, he took his large sheets from the blackboard to present them to us.

“The tiger is part of the breed of felines, like the cat, meow. The big difference is that the latter is able to swallow a dozen cute kittens for breakfast!!” he shouted.

“Arrghh!” Lily reacted, somewhat frightened by Anass’s presentation.

“Anass... please tone it down,” asked the teacher, calmly.



“Okay sir.” replied Anass. “The Bengal tiger can reach up to three metres in length and one metre in height. Some species can weigh up to 300 kilograms! Just imagine how many small rodents or birds it has to devour every day to fill its stomach... It’s even said that sometimes, when it doesn’t find enough food, it would approach villages in search of cute little children... And then... ROAAARRHH!!”

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“Whaaoooah!” Lily jumped again, along with half the class.

“Anass... please...” the teacher pleaded.

“Yes sir... The tiger is also super fast! It can reach up to 40 miles per hour!” Anass continued. “But the most impressive feat about this predator is its excellent hunting skills...”

Anass then reached into his bag and pulled out a small fluffy toy in the shape of a cat, which he placed at the front on a cardboard box.



He then moved into the middle of the classroom, crouched down and began to prowl around the tables. Staring at the stuffed animal, he mimicked the tiger hunting.

“The tiger first spots its prey, using its incredible eyesight and sharp sense of smell. Then, once the target is determined, he slowly approaches... very gently... without being noticed. He can sometimes remain motionless for more than an hour... to wait for the right moment.”



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And then, Anass did not move – fixed in position like a statue, his gaze still in the direction of the stuffed animal. In the classroom, it was total silence. Everyone was waiting for the outcome. Was the little kitten going to make it out alive?



"Anass... You have 1 minute left before the end..." the teacher whispered.

"Then, when the tiger determines it to be the right time with the wind blowing in the opposite direction and its prey distracted... he LUNGES FORWARD WITH HIS MOUTH OPEN! WRRAOOOAH!!"



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Woah! Without a moment's hesitation, Anass jumped over a desk before bouncing off another and finishing his spectacle at the front of the class with the stuffed animal in his mouth!



After witnessing this incredible performance, the whole class stood up to cheer Anass! It was a triumph!

After everyone settled, Anass picked up his papers and returned to his desk.

"Calm down, everyone!" ordered the teacher. "Well, I'm not entirely sure you understood the purpose of the contest Anass. The idea is that you would learn to express yourself well in public, not to act. I want you to develop skills you could use to present a new idea to potential investors, or conduct a sales meeting. Never the less, I will give you an eight out of ten for the work you have done."

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During break time, we talked about this morning's presentation.

"Wow..." said Rachid. "Anass really set his branch high with his tiger presentation."

"You mean the bar high," I corrected. "Yup, it's clear the pressure is on now. Anyway, what animal are you planning to choose as a subject?"

"I'm not sure..." Rachid pondered. "I'm looking for an animal that relates to me, but I still can't think of one."

"Same here," I exclaimed.

"Why don't you choose the camel?" Rachid offered.

"A camel?!?" I protested. "Is it because you think my head looks like a camel's?"



"Well... maybe a little." replied Rachid.

"Ha! Thanks very much!" I retorted. "How about you then? Why don't you choose a... a bear then?"

"A bear? Ha... But actually, that's a great idea! I've always loved those animals," replied Rachid. "I'll get a book from the library and prepare my presentation. Thanks Walad. Thanks from the bottom of my cart!"

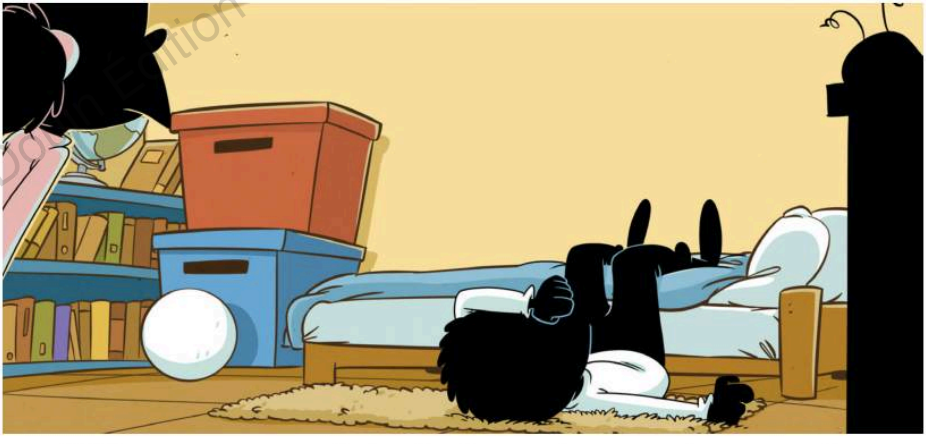
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“From the heart...! We say, from the bottom of our hearts!” I called out to Rachid.



With these words, Rachid left me alone on the bench as he skipped off towards the school library.
Pff... a camel? He could have suggested a lion. Or even a jaguar. But a camel?

At home, while I was lying around sluggishly in my room trying to think of an original animal idea, Binti joined me.



“What are you doing? Or rather... what aren’t you doing?” she asked.

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“I have to do a presentation on an animal for a public speaking contest at school. The problem is, I don’t know which animal to choose...” I replied. “By the way, which animal do you think represents me the best?”

“Hmm... what about the camel?” Binti exclaimed.

“Urghh... really...” I muttered.

“What’s the problem? A camel is great! It’s big, it’s strong, it’s resilient, and... and... it’s big!” Binti explained. “And back in the day, in the desert everyone dreamt of having this animal! Weren’t you the one that wanted to be a Bedouin anyway?”

“Sure... okay, why not? And anyway, what do you know about camels?” I questioned.

Binti then got up and took a book from my library.

“You have a dictionary of animals! In case you forgot, Mr. Clever Clogs...”



“Ah yes, good thinking!” I dug my nose deep into the book and found some surprising discoveries about this animal.

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I grabbed some papers, my wooden BDouin pencil and started sketching out some ideas for my upcoming presentation. Thankfully, Binti was there to help me design something unique and original.



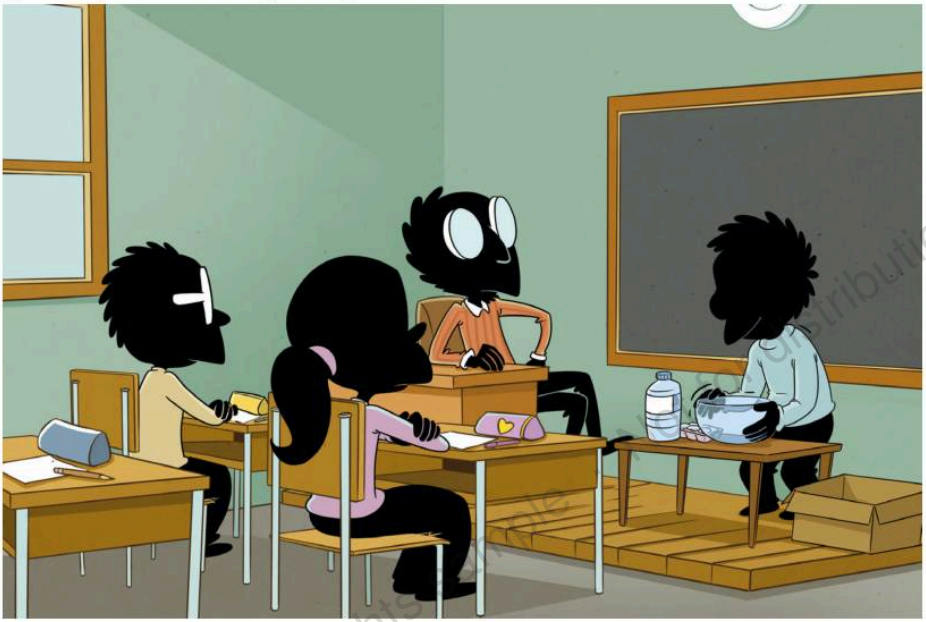
A week later, it was Rachid's turn to present his animal. He walked up to the front of the class with a cardboard box filled with... weird stuff.



On a table placed in the middle of the room, near the board, he took out all of his objects one by one:

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A big transparent salad bowl, a bag of ice cubes, a bottle of cold water, a pair of woolen gloves and a pair of rubber gloves, and finally... a pack of butter!



"Interesting... I'm curious to know what animal you have chosen Rachid," said the teacher, intrigued by what he saw.

"It's the polar bear!" Rachid replied, picking up a sheet of paper on which he'd written in small text. "It's a mammal that can weigh up to 800 kilograms and can run up to 25 miles per hour. He lives in the North Pole on the ice floe and isn't afraid to enter frozen water. There you go!" Rachid finished abruptly, putting the paper away in his pocket.

"Hmm... it's a bit short Rachid," exclaimed the teacher. "And what about all these things, what's it all about?"

"This is a practical demonstration to explain why the polar bear isn't cold when it's in freezing water." Rachid declared with confidence.

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